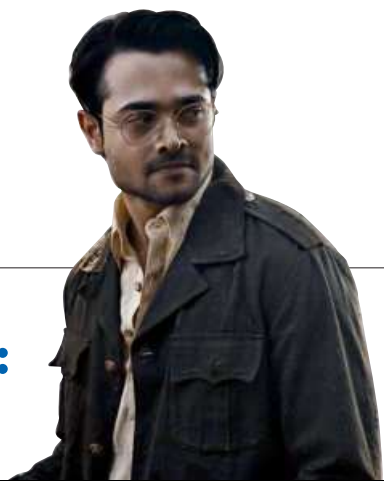




# metroPLUS

THE HINDU



**Madurai prepares to welcome** several lakh visitors today. Here is our guide to the city **P4**

**FROM YOUTUBER TO ACTOR:** BHUVAN BAM'S JOURNEY **P6**

PHOTO: SHIVARAJ S

Ahead of his upcoming Chennai concert, Walking Through the Rainbow, Yuvan Shankar Raja talks about taking scores globally, his father Ilaiyaraaja's influence, and why sometimes the best way out of a creative block is dessert

**Srinivasa Ramanujam**  
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**“D**rugs are legal here,” says a comment on a jukebox featuring his superhit tracks. For a generation of Tamil film audiences who grew up in the 2000s, heartbreak and happiness came accompanied by a song tuned by Yuvan Shankar Raja. For them, his voice oozes intoxication – it is no wonder that there are multiple playlists that are titled ‘UI Drugs’.

But his voice alone will not be in the forefront of Walking Through the Rainbow, a concert by the man this weekend in Chennai. A symphonic experience, it seeks to present a full-length orchestral experience of his iconic background scores that have been celebrated by Tamil cinema fans across the globe. Excerpts from an interview with the musician:

**Question:** When did you conceptualise the idea of a symphonic presentation of your work, and why is this special?

**Answer:** I like to break regular formats. I went to Hans Zimmer's concert in Abu Dhabi, and wished to do something on those lines. That took us to Walking Through the Rainbow, which is the first-ever concert built entirely around scores. We rehearsed the tracks with a symphony orchestra at Bangkok – some were very easy for them, but when it came to the music of 7G Rainbow Colony, they had to practise for almost half a day... which gave me the satisfaction that I had written a good score for that particular film. For me, be it the score or the songs, when I listen to my past work, I go back to the journey associated with it, and hence it is special. I believe audiences will experience the same feeling.

**Q:** Your background music has become popular in its own right. When you score this, what are you trying to achieve that is different from what you do with a song?

**A:** Everything we do is to elevate the film's sequences. Take the ‘Bat Theme’ in Chennai 600028, for instance. Venkat (director Venkat Prabhu) already had a tune from my father's work [Ilaiyaraaja's Apoorva Sagodargal emotional theme] for that situation, but I created a trap version around it. Before I embarked on Paruthiveeran's background score, I heard as much as possible of my father's and AR Rahman's folk work and decided to go the opposite way. I kept it as raw as possible. If you hear the score even today, you will find the nadaswaram player had made some mistakes. But I left it as such – because I wanted it to be like it is at a thiruvizha, where such missteps occur.

**Q:** A song has lyrics and singers to steer audience emotion. With background music, there are no words. How do you find that emotional language?

**A:** My scores and themes are usually not based on the songs in the film. I prefer taking the hard way, and do a score that has a connection with the songs of the film. Sometimes, the visual inspires me – Mankatha's chase sequence is one example. Sometimes, we take English scores and paste them on for a sequence – not as a rip off, but to understand the sound spectrum.



## The man behind the score

Simbu's Manmadhan was done like that.

**Q:** You're known for both romance and mass music. Which is tougher to crack?

**A:** Truth be told, both are not tough. Your mind has to be a clean slate when you start work. Creativity is about flow. If there's something amiss in the office, I cannot work. If my mind is clutter free, music flows.

My mind goes back to ‘Naane Varuven’, a score that Selvaraghavan and I worked for almost seven days. Dhanush heard it, and scrapped everything. But I managed to complete the entire score within 24 hours, because my mind was free. As a composer, I am like clay. I can mould myself according to what the makers seek in a project. This is a quality that I picked up from my father.

**On a flight, I heard a composition of my father from Tik Tik Tik (1981) on loop. I was taken aback by how he had managed to pull off those sounds, back in the Eighties. The minute I came back, I rushed to him to understand how that was done**

YUVAN SHANKAR RAJA

**A:** When I was in school, my only exposure to my dad's songs was through *Oliyum Oliyum* on TV. They would play the programme loudly at home and I would listen to the songs in the background even as I was playing. As time went by, I kept listening to hip-hop and RnB. I was in a zone where I thought, ‘We need to bring this kind of music here.’ I decided to do a private album, for which I listened to RD Burman and MS Viswanathan's work extensively. When I came to *appa's* work, the vehicle stopped (laughs).

### Yuvan's line-up

- City of Gold
- Raja's Playlist
- 7G Rainbow Colony – 2
- Bang Bang
- Paripadi (Malayalam)

**Q:** After becoming an established composer yourself, how much did your relationship with your father's music change?

**A:** I had gone to Melbourne to mix *Sarvam* (2009), and on the flight, I happened to hear ‘Netru Indrum Neram’ and another song from *Tik Tik Tik* (1981) on loop. I was taken aback by how he had managed to pull off those sounds, back in the Eighties.

The minute I came back, I rushed to him to understand how that was done. Then, I started noticing more of his background scores and realised that he is an encyclopaedia when it comes to music.

**Q:** Today social media is filled with a debate pitting Ilaiyaraaja versus AR Rahman. As a music fan, how do you view this debate?

**A:** I don't see it as a debate. I know ARR very well; his son, AR Ameen, hangs out with me all the time. There are no walls between composers. We all speak to each other. I'm unable to understand this discussion from a fan's point of view.

**Q:** Actor Ajith's Dheena (2001) was a turning point in your career. You share a warm camaraderie with him; last year, we saw you bonding with him in Dubai when he was practising for the Le Mans race. As a film industry colleague, how inspiring is it to see him pursue motor racing?

**A:** It is *vera* level to watch him. It's very easy for us to speak about car racing from a distance, but I have witnessed his struggles up close. He showed me recorded footage from his previous races. It is extremely inspiring to watch his passion.

**Q:** People close to you tell me that you are deeply spiritual. You converted to Islam. Has your spiritual pursuit influenced your musical journey too?

**A:** It has helped handle the stress around me. Be it losing someone or winning a big award, spirituality has helped me handle both these ends of the spectrum of life. It has helped me be more at peace.

Yuvan's Walking Through the Rainbow will be held at Nehru Indoor Stadium on September 19. Tickets on District.

## A city's chorus

The Madras MBS Choir came together at *The Hindu's* Made of Chennai archival photo exhibition to perform at the archival photo exhibition

**S Poorvaja**  
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**O**n Saturday, the Madras MBS Choir, the oldest surviving Indian choral music group in the country, took their places in two neat rows, in an unlikely location. Their stage for the evening was *The Hindu's* Made Of Chennai archival photo exhibition titled ‘Madras On Stage’; a setting that featured a slice of their history as well, amongst many other photographs exploring the story of the city's culture through its performances and public spaces.

As members excitedly pointed to a photo of the choir at the exhibition, clicked in December 2008 during a performance in Chennai, Gayathree Krishna, secretary said that at least seven members of the choir from that photo were there to perform at the exhibition.

Thirupurasundari Sevvell, founder, Nam Veedu Nam Oor Nam Kadhai who curated the exhibition, facilitated their performance.

“Formerly known as the Madras Youth Choir, the Madras MBS Choir was founded in 1971 by composer MB

Srinivasan, who was a pioneer of Indian choral music. He infused elements of western harmony into Indian choral music. Over the years, we have grown as a movement, to take Indian choral music to a wider audience,” Gayathree said.

Gayathree added that their repertoire draws from a range of Indian compositions that look beyond film music and religious compositions; songs about the environment, patriotism, social values and more, are sung across languages.

Of the current strength of over 40 members, some, like D Ramachandran, have been with the choir since its inception in 1971. “My love for music is what drew me to joining the choir. This is also a very unique genre, and singing with a group has not just given me energy, but also built my confidence over the years,” he said.

The members, ranging from teachers to writers and corporate professionals come together every Sunday for practice sessions and meetings.

Welcoming people of all ages to join, the choir is especially keen to see more youngsters come on board, united by a shared love of music and performance.



**Notes of joy**  
The Madras MBS Choir at *The Hindu's* Made of Chennai archival photo exhibition.  
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# Print on print

## A self-published book fair with eclectic comics, artists' books and prints? Sign us up

**Chitradeepa Anantharam**  
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The second edition of Kannadi Cupboard's annual self-published book fair, Padithavudan Kizhithuvudavum, is back. Kannadi Cupboard is an everyday gallery that brings together people with a desire to create. The fair showcases self-publishing artists from across the country. This 2026 edition features more than 300 titles and 12 exhibitors.

"The format unites artists working with illustrations, photographs, written material and more. The intention is to have conversations on art books and zines that we otherwise do not get to see in mainstream book fairs in Chennai," says Prasanna Venkatesh, co-founder, Kannadi Cupboard.

This year, he and his co-founder (and sister) Keerthana Alageshan are hosting a wider range of creators from Chennai, Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and other parts of the country who work with photography, illustration, poetry, zines, written material and various other creative forms. "About 32 authors from across India have sent material. This edition is more niche than before. From Chennai, we will

be showcasing Chennai Blast, an independent publishing house, and Red Eye Chapters, which curates titles from across the country. I have a table to myself which I will share with my sister," says Prasanna.

Self-published material is produced completely by individuals, as opposed to traditional publishing, which is done by publishing houses. In most cases, the material is written, photographed, illustrated and printed by the artist. "We periodically conduct zine fests, art book fairs, family cookbook potlucks, vinyl listening sessions and many other events. We wanted to look at a wide variety of material, with the overarching intention being self-published," says Prasanna.

Talking about the display plan, Prasanna says that the setup for the book fair is designed on the floor, which helps everyone slow down and interact at leisure. According to him, though sales are at the forefront of these fairs, the conversations are even more special.

*@Kannadi Cupboard, Tambaram. September 18 (3pm to 8pm), 19 and 20 (11am to 8pm). For details, call 9566017770.*



Looking through the window Zines, and independent creations at Kannadi Cupboard. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



**Elsa Sunny**  
elsa.sunny@thehindu.co.in

Eleven years ago, the land that now houses Dr Ambedkar Pagutharivu Padasalai, run by Vyasai Thozhargal in North Chennai's Vyasarpadi, was a sewage-filled stretch of abandoned Government land. Through collective effort, it was transformed into a tuition centre providing free classes to mostly Dalit students in the neighbourhood.

For Sarath Kumar, founder, Vyasai Thozhargal, this story reflects the potential of poromboke – the common space.

"We are running a tuition centre on poromboke land, which is an abandoned Government land. There are many such lands in the neighbourhood. Using such spaces, especially in underprivileged areas, is essential for marginalised communities," he says.

The idea of poromboke, or commons, will take centrestage at Porombokkiyal 2026, on September 19, presented by Chennai Kalai Thiru Vizha. The day-long programme will feature four sessions exploring the many forms of commons, from roads and public spaces to music and the Internet, and the ways in which communities create, share and care for them.

# Shaping the commons

## At Porombokkiyal, join a shared space to discuss Chennai's cultural resources that mould everyday life

The session, Commons of Care, hosted by wetland researcher and campaigner Prashant Jack, will explore collective action, reciprocity and the relationships of care that sustain communities. "The meaning of the word poromboke is commons. No individual can claim ownership over it," says Prashant. "Over the decades, however, the word came to be associated with wasteland and acquired a negative connotation. We want to revisit its original meaning."

While previous editions of

**At its core, Porombokkiyal is built on the belief that knowledge does not belong only to institutions or degree holders**

Porombokkiyal focussed on rural areas, this year turns its attention to urban spaces. "Often we think commons are restricted to rural spaces. But this year, by discussing commons in urban areas, we encourage people to recognise that they exist all around them – in roads, beaches, and other shared spaces that shape everyday life," says Monali Bala, musician and organiser of Porombokkiyal.

The discussion titled Many lives of a Road will bring together speakers whose experiences are closely tied to these spaces. Among them is Mullai, who sells fish on Marina Beach Loop Road; Mohana Sundari, an auto driver who navigates the city's roads every day; and Dr Aiswarya Rao, who uses a wheelchair and will speak about accessibility in public spaces. Another speaker, Yuvan Aves,

**Reclaiming the poromboke** TM Krishna in conversation with Sasikumar P, a mukavinai artiste at Porombokkiyal 2024. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nature educator of Palluyir Trust, expands the conversation further by asking whether trees, animals and other non-human beings also have a stake in the commons.

At its core, Porombokkiyal is built on the belief that knowledge does not belong only to institutions or degree holders. Fisherfolk, forest dwellers and local communities possess generations of knowledge that often remain overlooked.

Just as degree holders and researchers are considered experts in their respective fields, generational knowledge passed down through generations makes people knowledgeable about their own fields of expertise, says Monali.

The discussion, Sharing Fairly – Music, Internet & the Ethics of the Commons, will be moderated by TM Krishna, singer and an organiser. It will explore the Internet as a form of commons and examine questions of ownership, access and ethics in the digital age.

"The Internet is supposed to be a democratic space, but it doesn't function so," says Krishna. "Right now, everyone is recording and hosting content. What about the ethics of the Internet? That's where questions of copyright and intellectual property come in. These are all complex questions."

As Porombokkiyal heads into its fourth edition, Krishna hopes the conversations will encourage people to think more deeply about the commons and their own role within it. "After every conference, I believe people go back with a greater understanding of things that are often taken for granted. I hope it influences the way they think about their actions in society and also lead to greater respect for different kinds of knowledge."

*Porombokkiyal 2026 is on September 19, 10am onwards at Trace the Space, Mylapore. Entry is free.*

Anisha Menezes

Cheese as far as the eye could see. With 45 cheese samples from 20 cheesemakers across India, it was a great way to spend a Saturday, at the first event of the Indian Artisanal Cheese Association hosted at The Farm, Semmencheri.

Kalari (mixed milk and whey-based cheese) travelling from Kashmir, to Balmithai Brunost (toffee-like whey cheese) from Bazpur, Uttarakhand, Bandel from Bengal to spreadable cheese redolent with pungent garlic or the firm Tomme de Semmencheri, there was a cornucopia of soft, semi-hard and hard cheese from across the country. There was barely an inch to spare on the two large cheese tables, piled high with condiments like roasted honey almonds, sharp mustard, fig preserve, crackers and crudité.

India is the world's largest producer of milk, yet how much do we really know about artisanal Indian cheese?

Mansi Jasani, founder, The Bombay Cheese Collective, says the terroir makes the cheese. "We go to the source — keeping the animal at the centre, the land, its feed, the season and those collectively define how the cheese will turn out. This is vastly different from industrially made commercial



# Grate expectations

## Cheesemakers gather at The Farm in Chennai for the first event of the Indian Artisanal Cheese Association

cheese where the end product is defined and the process is tailored from start to finish to meet that standard."

The other founder-directors are a motley crew of affineurs (cheese makers), cheesemongers and cheese consultants – Arul Putnani (The Farm), Namrata Sundaresan (Käse), Debarati Nandee Laederich (Amiksa, Himachal Pradesh),

Mausam Narang (Elephtheria Cheese, Mumbai), Mukund Naidu (Artisan and Gourmet, Bengaluru) and Hemangini Sinha (Khet se Plate, Ahmedabad).

Monika Kapoor Sarkhel, founder, Mira Maia Micro



**Happiness on bread** (Left) Spread of cheese from different cheesemongers at the event; (inset) tower of cheese. VINCY VICTOR AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Creamery based in New Delhi, was taking around plates of freshly toasted Kalari, stretchy like mozzarella yet with a buttery smoothness and grassy notes. "We mix cow, buffalo, sheep and goat milk and add two-day-old fermented whey to it, after bringing it to 65-70 degrees Celsius. So without rennet, you get this soft cheese that's best consumed warm with a dash of hot sauce. We wrap it in banana leaves and it is packed this way to keep it shelf stable to ship across India," she explains.

For IACA, cheese advocacy is central to its foundation. "IACA is not about creating an association with a calendar of events. It's about building the infrastructure that this industry needs – better standards, knowledge sharing, better conversations around milk and dairy, and a platform that can represent Indian cheese both here and internationally," concludes Namrata Sundaresan.

*For membership to this association log on to indianartisanalcheeseassociation.com*

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## METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #71 (Set by Doppelganger)

### Across

- 1 Vascular plant tissue (7)
  - 5 Tag (5)
  - 8 Scarf for warmth (7)
  - 9 So long (5)
  - 10 Get up (5)
  - 11 Plain (7)
  - 12 Scatter fluid (6)
  - 14 Return money ahead of due date (6)
  - 17 Healthful (7)
  - 19 A sacred song (5)
  - 22 Toward the stern (5)
  - 23 No longer in use (7)
  - 24 A line of shrubs (5)
  - 25 Possessing human features (7)
- ### Down
- 1 Punctuation mark (5)
  - 2 Muslim legal scholar (5)
  - 3 Disease (7)

- 4 English folk dance (6)
- 5 Falsifiers (5)
- 6 Rock music by U.K. bands (7)
- 7 Washing room (7)
- 12 Tolerate (7)

### Solution No. 71

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To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

On the jasmine trail

Walk down any by-lane in Madurai and you will find coils of jasmine. To douse yourself in the fragrance of the delicate, green-stemmed flower, visit the flower markets at Mattuthavani and Villapuram. On a jasmine trail at these markets, one can see hillocks of jasmine, *mullai*, *sampangi*, rose, lotus, and marigold, not to mention garlands that artisans weave with mechanical precision. While there, pause to observe women string jasmine: their fingers deftly work to create strands that adorn not just temple deities, but the hair of every other Madurai woman. Madurai malli is GI-tagged for its distinctive fragrance and round shape. According to Tamil Nadu Agritech Portal, it is exported to places such as Singapore, Malaysia, Sri Lanka, West Asia and the United States.



Destination:

Madurai

Today marks the Meenakshi temple’s 2026 kumbabhishekam. Take a deep dive into Madurai – discover the heritage of its hand-made sungudi, the jasmine markets, origins of jigarthanda, buzz of the Teppakulam, and some of the city’s best vadas

Akila Kannadasan and Sanjana Ganesh  
akila.k@thehindu.co.in and sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in



PHOTOS: G MOORTHY, R ASHOK AND THANGARATHINAM N

Simply, sungudi

Legend has it that the Saurashtrian community that migrated from Gujarat to Madurai in the late 16th and early 17th Century, thrived under Nayak rule. During this time, they brought to the city a tie-and-dye tradition, using stones, thread, and naturally occurring pigments on saris, to make patterns in more permutations and combinations than imaginable. Today, only a handful of the members living around the Mahal area where their ancestors lived, continue this handloom tradition. Much of the labour-intensive work has been replaced by machine prints. However, some warriors continue to fiercely protect tradition. To watch the sari making process up-close, contact Cholan Tours Madurai at 8220005542. If you want to take one home, drop by Tharagai Sungudi, a shop in BB Kulam, which works with 20 women from in and around Madurai, training them in making sungudi. Their store selling authentic saris (ranging from ₹2,000-₹15,000), as well as material, is open from Monday to Friday. Contact 8124361714 for details.

Jostle for jigarthanda

The best way to counter Madurai’s heat? A tall, chilled glass of jigarthanda. There are several shops across the city that sell the caramel-coloured dessert. Famous Jigarthanda, though, is where it all began. Head to their Kamarajar Street outlet – be warned, it is always crowded – jostle your way through the packed counter in the front to order a glass of the drink that consists of jelly-like bits of badam *pisin*, ice cream, *basundhi*, and *nannari* syrup. The shop has 20 branches across the city and the one on Kamarajar Street has a spacious parlour nearby with wooden benches for customers to sit and enjoy their drink. Sheik Meeran, the founder, operated from a push-cart in the same spot in the 1970s.



Nuggets of history

It is in Madurai that the world first learnt of a civilisation from the Vaigai valley. Amid coconut groves in Keeladi, about 12 kilometres from Madurai, experts have unearthed artefacts to be 2,000 to 2,500 years old, with the oldest dating back to around 580BC. The location is an absolute must for history lovers, and is open from 10am to 6pm on weekdays and till 7pm on weekends with an entry fee of ₹15 for adults. Besides this, do not be surprised if you come upon a historical monument dating back to the Nayaks during a shopping spree. For, the city has some interesting structures that are part of everyday life. One such is the Pathu Thoon Street, a bustling marketplace that is home to

stately stone pillars. According to historians, the pillars belong to an extended palace from the Nayak period. The unfinished Raya Gopuram at the entrance of Yezhukadal Veedhi near the Meenakshi temple is another sight to behold. Also constructed by the Nayaks, it would have made a magnificent gateway had it been completed. But it stands unfinished, its stone sculptures looking out of place in a crowded street. It was after a visit to Madurai that Mahatma Gandhi decided to adopt the simple attire he is known for. Gandhi Memorial Museum has several rare artefacts relating to the freedom fighter, the highlight of which is the blood-stained cloth that was wrapped around him when he was assassinated on January 30, 1948.

Keelakuyilkudi village and 100 steps

A drive on the Madurai-Theni highway will lead you to the picture-perfect Keelakuyilkudi village 15 kilometres from Madurai. This is where you will spot a hillock of deep historical significance dating back to 2,000 years. Welcome to Samanar Malai where a stunning bas relief of Mahavira and two attendants; inscriptions that date to the 9th and 10th Century; and rock-cut sculptures of Gomateshwara, Mahavira, Yakshi and Yaksha, can be spotted. Take the long climb with over a hundred steps to look at all the bas relief structures. A pond here will make the physical effort worth it. There is a Brahmi inscription further up the hill too. One can visit the hill between 6am and 6pm. Entry is free.

Manapatty Murugesan Mess

A relatively new entrant in the scene, this eatery features wedding-style biryani made the way caterers in Manapatty village would make it. It was started eight months ago by the father-son duo P Murugesan and M Balasundhar, who want to popularise the non-vegetarian dishes of their village in Melur. Murugesan is one among several popular wedding caterers from Manapatty, a village known for being home to several wedding caterers. The biryani here is made with seeraga samba rice and is richer and less spicy than the Dindigul variety. Apart from typical vegetarian and non-vegetarian meals that include the *elumbu kuzhambu*, *kudal kuzhambu*, and *chinna vengaya oorga*, Manapatty Murugesan Mess also serves a signature mutton *nei chukka*. The dish consists of slow-cooked mutton and plenty of cashews for that crunch, left to soak in the nutty flavour of gingelly oil. At Shenbagathottam Colony, Melamadai



PHOTOS: G MOORTHY, R ASHOK, AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Chukka, please

Madurai may well have the best non-vegetarian food in Tamil Nadu. This trail takes you through our favourite messes, from the iconic Chandran Mess to Amsavalli Bhavan. Try *ayirai meen kuzhambu*, *kari dosa* and *kola urundai*

Akila Kannadasan  
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Amsavalli Bhavan

Amsavalli is a good place to begin your day if you are looking for a heavy breakfast. Started 75 years ago, the restaurant on East Veli Street has an old-world charm: think marble-topped tables and a hand-painted nameboard. They are best known for their mutton offal dishes such as liver curry, brain fry, and kidney curry, paired with uthappams and parottas. The mutton *nenju* chops, a semi-dry curry, and the fiery mutton *chukka* go well with their flaky parottas. Round-off breakfast with a chilled glass of their famous apple milk that consists of tiny pieces of apple served with thick, sweet milk. Open for breakfast from 9.30am to 11am. At 42, East Veli Street, Nelpettai

Chandran Mess

Tourists and residents alike swear by Chandran Mess’ *ayirai meen kuzhambu*. It consists of a tangy curry simmered with shallots, curry leaves, and a masala ground by R Banumathi, the matriarch of the family that runs the place. They are also known for *viraal meen* roast that comes coated in a spicy masala, courtesy Banumathi. Pair this with their fragrant rasam. Mutton *chukka*, a dense, thick gravy in which the meat is let to simmer in a red chilli-based masala and *naatu kozhi* chops, also go well with rice. Chandran Mess’ *kola urundai*, a deep-fried dish of minced mutton that is infused with the flavour of fennel and cumin seeds, is another must-try. At 19 P, Vinayaga Nagar, KK Nagar, Third Street, opposite the District Court, and 49, Alagar Kovil Main Road, Tallakulam



Amma Mess

Think Amma Mess and its famous *ayirai meen kuzhambu* comes to mind. But the eatery has a cult following for its other dishes as well: *nandu* omelette, *mutta kari*, mutton *chukka*, *nalli elumbu* chops and *nenjelumbu* chops. Their *elai sappadu* is hugely popular. The meal lets one try all their spicy gravies with rice. Customers usually order a *kola urundai* or two, and there is also fish fry to try. Amma Mess is popular amidst the Tamil film fraternity, many of whom plan regular trips to Madurai for their fix of mutton and chicken specials. At 136, Alagar Kovil Main Road, Tallakulam

Also try lunch here

Kumar Mess is known for *kari dosa*, mutton liver and brain fry; Hotel Sri Janakiram for mutton *chukka* and biryani; order parotta, *milagu kulambu* and *kari dosa* at Arumugam Mess; and visit Simmakal Konar Kadai for *kari dosa*.



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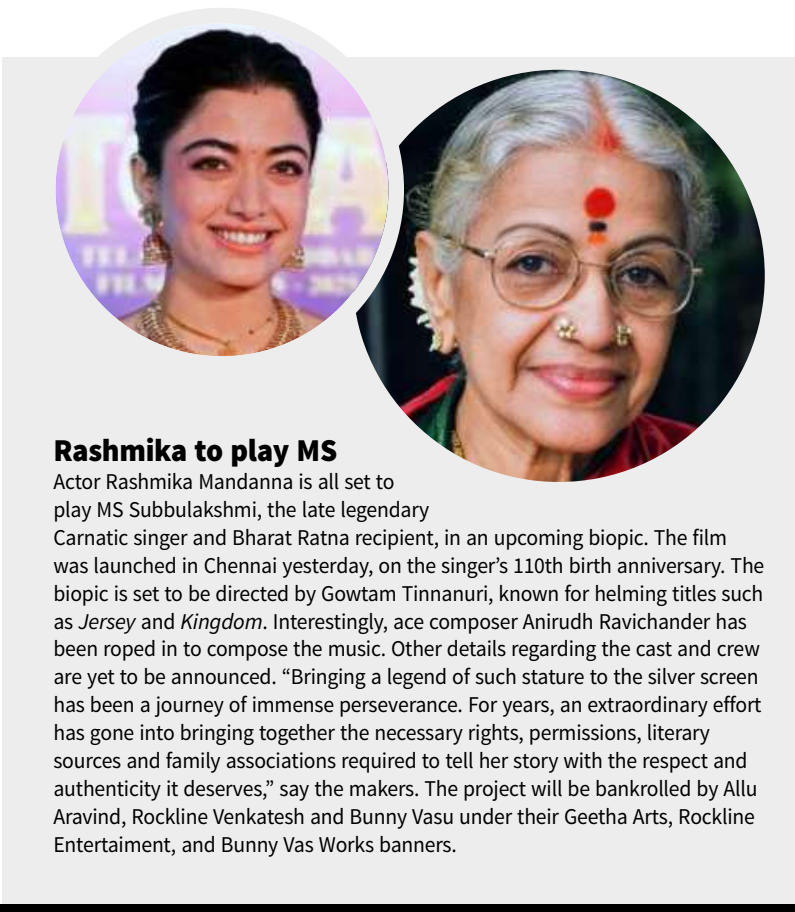
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Get ready for **Mookuthi Amman 2**

The makers recently unveiled the teaser for Nayanthara's much-awaited devotional thriller, *Mookuthi Amman 2 - Maha Sakthi*. The film, a sequel to director RJ Balaji's 2020 film, is directed

by acclaimed filmmaker Sundar C. The teaser hints at a larger-than-life Amman story set in both the past and the present day. We see how the queen of a kingdom sacrifices herself to save her son from enemies. Mookuthi Amman returns to save the child, but that's not all. The teaser also hints at an all-new evil power: a mysterious woman (played by Regena Cassandra). Above all, the teaser hints at a major shift in storytelling tone: while the first *Mookuthi Amman* film was a social satire with ample comedy, Sundar C's film seems to be the quintessential serious Amman movie. Written by Venkatt Ragavan, *Mookuthi Amman 2* also stars BR Vijayakumar, Urvashi, Yogi Babu, Ilavarasan, Maina Nandini, Ramachandra Raju, MG Abhinaya, and Shruthy S, among others. Y Gee Mahendra, Sneha and Khushboo are also mentioned in the cast, though it remains unknown if they are making cameo appearances. *Mookuthi Amman 2* is set for a release in theatres on November 6 during Deepavali.



**Rashmika to play MS**

Actor Rashmika Mandanna is all set to play MS Subbulakshmi, the late legendary Carnatic singer and Bharat Ratna recipient, in an upcoming biopic. The film was launched in Chennai yesterday, on the singer's 110th birth anniversary. The biopic is set to be directed by Gowtam Tinnanuri, known for helming titles such as *Jersey* and *Kingdom*. Interestingly, ace composer Anirudh Ravichander has been roped in to compose the music. Other details regarding the cast and crew are yet to be announced. "Bringing a legend of such stature to the silver screen has been a journey of immense perseverance. For years, an extraordinary effort has gone into bringing together the necessary rights, permissions, literary sources and family associations required to tell her story with the respect and authenticity it deserves," say the makers. The project will be bankrolled by Allu Aravind, Rockline Venkatesh and Bunny Vasu under their Geetha Arts, Rockline Entertainment, and Bunny Vas Works banners.



**Power House is Vikram's next**

*Power House* is the title of Tamil star Vikram's upcoming film with director Anand Shankar, the makers announced with a title announcement teaser. The film will release in 2027. The title teaser introduces Vikram as the man who runs Nalla Thambi Catering Service with his family, which includes his sister (played by Riya Shibu) and mother (Urvashi). After overseeing the preparations for a wedding, he steps into a dark passageway at the back of the house. In a classic Vikram-esque moment, we realise that in a storage room, he has tied a man to a chair while another is hung upside down from the ceiling. When the latter grunts and struggles upon seeing Vikram, the hero calms him and says, "I have just started cooking, haven't I? I promise to send you back after a full meal. 100% guarantee." The teaser doesn't give out any details about the plot. The cast also features MS Bhaskar, Shammy Thilakan, VTV Ganesh, and Samyuktha Hegde.



**Actor and YouTuber Bhuvan Bam on balancing creativity with strategy, and playing Rash Behari Bose in *The Revolutionaries***

Meteoric rise

**Suchin Mehrotra**

“A good artiste is someone who can market themselves,” says Bhuvan Bam. The actor and YouTuber knows a thing or two about self-promotion, with over 20 million Instagram followers and close to 30 million YouTube subscribers. Bam started his YouTube journey in 2015, uploading skits and sketches about middle-class life. In less than a year, he had over a million subscribers. By 2018, he became the first Indian YouTuber to have over 10 million subscribers. Bam is stepping into his ‘actor era’, with his first lead role in a streaming show not produced by

him. In Prime Video's recently released *The Revolutionaries*, he plays Rash Behari Bose, a mastermind who makes it his life's mission to cripple British rule in the early 1910s. Edited excerpts from a freewheeling chat:

**Question:** I want to go back to the start of your 'storytelling chapter', when you were co-writing and co-creating streaming shows you star in. It started with *Dhindhora* back in 2021. What went through your mind when you first thought about the idea?

**Answer:** Only two or three people in my team knew I was thinking of something like this. I hustled a lot for that show; I'm very proud of it. I

initially thought of it as a movie, but then *Sacred Games* came out, and OTT shows started in India. I thought, 'What if I divide the movie into eight episodes?' I had met Susan Wojcicki (YouTube CEO) briefly when she came to Mumbai, and I mentioned I wanted to do something bigger with my characters, and she told me to meet her whenever I was done ideating.

When the concept for *Dhindhora* was clear in my head, I realised she was at the World Economic Forum in Davos. So I spoke to my YouTube India team, and I asked them to make it happen.

I was the only young chap in Switzerland amidst all these world leaders, and I met her

during a party and started pitching the show. She said, 'I don't want to listen. We're making the show.' That's when I started telling people that I was doing something like this.

Then we started pre-production. It was the first time my team and I used outside vendors and worked with a crew, and none of them understood what we were doing. They would see me shoot scenes as one character, then change and come back as another character and shoot those scenes. They found it very strange.

**Q:** You've said that when you started getting acting offers, it was often from producers who just wanted you for your online

**Breaking new ground**

Bhuvan Bam in a still from *The Revolutionaries*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

following. What were those meetings like, and what made *The Revolutionaries* offer different?

**A:** The meetings the marketing team presented were the ones where you knew they were only interested in your followers. But with Nikkhil sir, it was never like that. He does not care about all that, he is a creative mind.

He just asked me if I wanted to perform the way he wanted or approach it differently. I told him Rash Behari Bose is already a big legend, but there is very little video footage of him, so there was the advantage of making the character my own. And Nikkhil sir was always there to guide me.

This was the first project where I was just an actor and didn't have to get involved in all the logistics, which was very freeing.

**Q:** And now you've just finished shooting a *Dharma* movie. How did that happen?

**A:** I owe a lot to *The Revolutionaries*. Nikkhil sir told Karan (Johar) that I'm playing Bose in the show. Then Karan told me he had a few film ideas he wanted to run by me. We've talked about other projects in the past, but I didn't feel those were worth being a part of, and he was very gracious.

And I heard the idea for *Kuku Ki Kundali*. It was just a first draft, but I felt like there was so much scope to make it exciting. But I told him I'd like to be creatively involved, especially in the jokes that were working and weren't working, and he gave me that space.

And there were workshops and readings, I got to act with Mr. (Manoj) Pahwa, which was amazing. I had a blast with the cast, including Wamiqa (Gabbi) and Sharon Sharma, the director.

Tunnel vision

Indie filmmaker Sangakiri Rajkumar spent six years in the making of *One Man*

**Bhuvanesh Chandar**

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S ankagiri Rajkumar's *One Man*, recently released in theatres, has been the subject of discussion in the Tamil film industry, with celebrities like Silambarasan TR and RV Udayakumar praising Rajkumar's effort. He wrote the film, designed the sets, makeup and costumes, performed, shot, edited the footage, composed music, applied computer graphics, and released the film.

Rajkumar says he was inspired by many similar experimental films made around the world – films entirely shot inside a car or a room.

*One Man*, which Rajkumar started before the pandemic in 2020, has taken six long years to see the light of day. Moreover, making this film was the only professional endeavour Rajkumar undertook all these years. "You can't do this part-time. You need to delve into each technical department as deeply as possible. But whenever I felt exhausted, performing therukoothu gave me some respite since it's much more raw and real." The making of the film too halted several times in the six years, says Rajkumar.

Rajkumar has released *One Man* on YouTube for premium subscribers. "I don't have a choice. At least I managed to get a few theatres to screen my film, but the OTT business needs a strong theatrical performance. *One Man* has unfortunately been caught in this commercial cycle."



**Multi-tasker** Sankagiri Rajkumar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Express Avenue mall turns sporting arena as the Tamil Nadu Pickleball Premier League returns for its second season, with celebrity team owners backing the sport

A DOSE OF PICKLEBALL

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Chennai's Express Avenue mall will throw up something different this weekend: sporting action. The mall will host the second season of the Tamil Nadu Pickleball Premier League (TNPPL), giving the city an opportunity to witness the world's fastest-growing sport at close quarters. With 12 district-based franchises and 168



**Eyes on the ball** Players in action. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

players fighting for a prize pool of ₹30 lakh, the league – aimed exclusively at Tamil Nadu players – hopes to make the State the pickleball capital of the country.

As Dr Kavya Somesh, general secretary, Tamil Nadu Pickleball Association, says, "For four days, people in Chennai won't just hear about pickleball... They will walk right into an electrifying atmosphere they cannot look away from."

The players cannot wait. Ask Prajnesh Gunneswaran, a tennis champion who won singles bronze in the 2018 Jakarta Asian Games and retired from the game in 2024. Prajnesh, a key player of the Ooty Bisons team, picked up the sport because "there are enough parallels to tennis".

"It's a lot of fun and we have a thriving community of players," says Prajnesh. One of the top players in the pro contingent, Prajnesh's move to pickleball was to primarily utilise his proficiency in racquet skills, something that he picked up over years of practise on tennis courts. The investments from owners are getting



**Sports re-entered my life through pickleball. I've been learning the game too. I am thrilled to have acquired my sondha ooru team**

KEERTHI PANDIAN  
Nellai Superstars

bigger as well; in fact, TNPPL's auction this season saw a bid by Coimbatore Smashers for ₹1.2 lakh for Anish Froilan.

Apart from sporting champions, the presence of celebrities is drawing more attention to the league; owning some of the teams are film personalities like Vikram (Cuddalore Kings), Varalaxmi Sarathkumar (Chennai Tamizh Titans) and Keerthy Pandian (Nellai Superstars). For actor Keerthy, owning a team



**I'm obsessed with pickleball. When I'm not shooting, I'm busy playing the sport. In this age of feeling lonely, it is creating friendships and fostering community**

VARALAXMI SARATHKUMAR  
Chennai Tamizh Titans



in the league is a chance for her to re-kindle her forgotten tryst with sport.

"As an athlete and kho-kho player, sports had been a big part of my school life, but it vanished after college. It has now re-entered my life through pickleball," says Keerthy, who has been learning to play too.

If Keerthy is batting for Nellai, Varalaxmi Sarathkumar is cheering

for the Chennai Tamizh Titans. "Owning a sports team is a dream come true," she says, adding that she plays the game at least thrice a week. "I'm obsessed with it. When I'm not shooting a film, I head to the courts to play the game. People all over the world are moving to pickleball. In this age of feeling lonely, it is creating friendships and fostering community." The league, she says, will go a long way in not only creating a big pool of professional players but also encouraging amateurs. "It will grow bigger, and hopefully, it will become as big as the IPL (Indian Premier League) someday."

That's for the future, but for now, inside the atrium of the EA mall, you could become a pickleball fan. "You could be out shopping, but the rallies and crowd might draw you in," adds Dr Kavya, who believes that the sport is a perfect stress-relieving antidote for busy professionals, "Pickleball is loud, fast, and visually addictive. Once you start playing, there is no turning back."

**Entry is free for Cavin's TNPPL Season 2, to be held from September 17 to 20 at Express Avenue atrium, Chennai. For details, visit tnppl.com.**